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From the editor-in-chief

As much as India has been a growing economic power in the first decade of the 21st century, it has also been a country that has dealt with repeated attacks on its security and the well-being of its citizens.

In a few weeks India will mark the first anniversary of the horrific 26/11 attack on Mumbai. India's relations with its neighbours are far from cordial. While there was no major cross-border terrorist attack after 26/11, the war within Pakistan is a cause for concern. India's engagement with China continues to remain extremely fractious. Just before going to print this week, a Rajdhani train with almost 500 passengers was held hostage for five hours by a group said to be supportive of Maoist insurgents. The average urban Indian has only just absorbed the fact that Naxalites in more than 200 districts are engaged in a war with the state and are willing to kill anyone they consider their enemies.

India's security is central to its survival and it is why after 26/11 we decided to form the INDIA TODAY Board of Experts on Security and Terror (BEST). Our Board consists of two Army Generals, one Air Vice Marshal, a former Ambassador, one former Governor, a former Intelligence Chief, one former Director-General of Police, two leading professors and the head of a security think tank. They provide a wide range of experience and expertise. The first meeting was called in March this year in which they were highly critical of the Government post-26/11. Their deliberations were published in our edition of April 13, 2009.

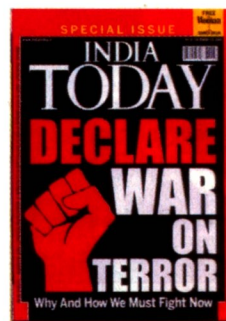
This was part of the INDIA TODAY "War on Terror" campaign which continued well after the 26/11 headlines had vanished off TV and evaporated in print. The campaign is intended to keep our readers informed about the real issues involved in security and terror and what action needs to be taken.

In the current BEST meeting we put several key questions to our Board members. In the last 12 months, India's internal security situation has stabilised when it comes to cross-border incidents. We wanted to find out whether this was merely good fortune or whether the Government had tightened their controls and their vigilance. Their answers were far more assuring than at the last meeting.

Asking the latest questions about Pakistan, its own internal strife and continued external wranglings with India was the next question. Our experts also shed important light on India's rising tensions with China, the latest one being on the Dalai Lama's planned visit to Arunachal Pradesh. Internally though, another issue has risen to the top of the national agenda, the Naxalite terror, and it was important to understand its antecedents and how it could be tackled in the future.

Our cover story this week is a perfect spotlight on the major security concerns that affect India at the moment. All the rapid economic growth is worthless if a nation does not feel secure from within and outside its borders. I believe the security of our country should be an institutional process and a non-partisan issue. Our political establishment should evolve a broad consensus on the security issues facing the country. The objective of forming the Board of Experts and publishing their discussions is to facilitate such an outcome.

(Aroon Purie)



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